

“It is all from Wakan-Tanka [the buffalo] that the Holy Man has wisdom and the power to heal.”

CHIEF FLAT-IRON OF THE OGLALA SIOUX IN NATALIE CURTIS' *THE INDIANS' BOOK*, 1907

Fishlike scales for hair suggest a connection with water



Natural rounding of boulder used to form chin

▲ River deity protecting fishermen

This is one of a series of more than 50 monumental sandstone heads set up in front of the hearths of a Neolithic fishing village called Lepenski Vir beside the Danube in Serbia. The heads may represent guardian river deities.

Figures of fecundity

Fertility, too, preoccupied early peoples, as without new life their tribe would die. Many figurines of women with exaggerated hips and breasts have been found in caves. The physical characteristics of these figures are thought to suggest that people were calling on a mother goddess to bless them with children. Some of the statuettes were portable (perhaps to be held in the hand), such as the “Venus” figurines—ancient European sculptures believed to date from the Paleolithic era. One feature common to the Venus figures is the lack of facial detail, perhaps to give them universal appeal rather than resemblance to a specific individual.

Magic of the dead

Perhaps more potent than hunting, fertility, or the earth’s mysteries was the fear of death. Formal burials have been found, dating from as early as 60,000 BCE, containing bones scattered with red ocher (suggestive of blood). Some burials also included flowers or necklaces to accompany the deceased into the next life. At Kebara Cave in Israel, Neanderthals buried several skeletons and skull bones, probably as a post-mortem rite.

Early peoples, too, seem to have had a fear of dead spirits. At Gough’s Cave in Somerset, incisions on bones that are around 15,000 years old indicate that they engaged in ritual cannibalism. The aim of this may have been to acquire the powers of the dead or to prevent their spirits from inflicting damage on the living.